

FAST FORWARD
Surekha Yadav drives the Vande Bharat Express

LOCO PILOTS

DRIVEN TO DESPAIR

a monthly salary of Rs 35,000, which includes a "running allowance" calculated at 30 per cent of her basic pay, based on the number of hours she has spent inside a locomotive. The money increases with the years and progressions made in the job. "But if I knew they didn't have even basic facilities for women employees, I would not have taken the job," she says firmly. The predicament of women loco pilots is rendered more acute during menstrual cycles, or when pregnant or lactating. An assistant loco pilot in South Central Railway recalls when she had her menstrual cycles "and had to change my sanitary napkins in another loco". Following the incident, her parents had tried to stop her from going to work, but "it's hard to let go of a government job".

It is common for Indian Railways to take to social media on International Women's Day every year on March 8 and share photos of their women loco pilots. Last year in March, 58-year-old Surekha Yadav, Asia's first woman loco pilot who is now posted in Central Railway, became the first woman to drive the semi-high-speed Vande Bharat Express. For this, the Railways give Yadav separate toilet and restroom facilities in the running rooms, say those in the know. But women loco pilots INDIA TODAY spoke to claimed it was an exception and alleged that they were stuck in a job that was designed for men over a century back. According to them, while their performance was expected to be on par with their male counterparts, they have to constantly battle the absence of basic workplace amenities. The women are also demanding office roles during pregnancy, alleging that there have been instances of women loco pilots suffering miscarriages owing to the strenuous nature of the job; Railways has always refused to make it a policy specifically for women loco pilots. They also want home drop after running hours.

Pushed by their travails, women loco pilots wrote to the chief labour commissioner (central) in January, alleging violation of International Labour Organization conventions on duty hours and workplace conditions. The petition, made through the Indian Railway Loco Runningmen Organisation (IRLRO), also calls for necessary amendments to the Railways Act, 1989, to make rules conducive to the working of women. According to information accessed by INDIA TODAY, the chief labour commissioner's office held a meeting with members of the union and Railway Board officials on January 16. The officials are said to have agreed to discuss the issues. A multi-party committee has been formed under the chief labour commissioner with members from the Railways, the unions, a woman loco pilot and a representative of the ministry of women and child development. The IRLRO is also pushing the cause of women loco pilots. "We did a formal

- **IN 2016,** the National Human Rights Commission ordered that toilets and airconditioning be provided in locomotives
- Women locopilots claim there are no toilets on locos and no separate toilets or changing rooms for them at running rooms
- Railway workers unions have written to the authorities in the past to provide these facilities for women locopilots
- **IN JANUARY,** women locopilots wrote to Chief Labour Commissioner (Central) alleging violation of International Labour Organisation conventions
- **IN FEBRUARY,** the women submitted their grievances to Railway Board Chairperson and CEO Jaya Varma Sinha